

Indochina Colonized

In the 19th century, at the height of European imperialism, France seized control of Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia to create French Indochina. However, the Vietnamese had a history of resistance to foreign domination and France found its rule fiercely contested.

◀◀ BEFORE

The Vietnamese formed their first kingdom in the Red River Valley some 3,000 years ago.

OUT OF CHINA'S SHADOW

The Vietnamese were ruled by China from 111 BCE, but acts of rebellion—including the uprising led by the Trưng sisters in around 40 CE—would result in **Vietnamese independence** in 939. Further wars enabled the Vietnamese to expand southward and by the start of the 19th century, they occupied much the same territory as modern-day Vietnam.

French influence over Vietnam began with the introduction of French Catholic missionaries: in 1802, French bishop Pigneau de Béhaine helped Emperor Gia Long to defeat the Son Tay rebellion and ascend to the throne. However, the emperor's successors turned against the Catholics, and wanted to limit French involvement. In 1858, the persecution of Catholics gave a pretext for the French to invade Cochin China, an area of Vietnam that included Saigon and the Mekong Delta.

In the mid-19th century, the momentum of imperialism was unstoppable. The major European powers, utterly convinced of their cultural supremacy, carved up the world between them, taking advantage of their military and technological superiority. Once the French established themselves in Cochin China—officially declared a French colony in 1864—it was only a matter of time before France extended its “protection” over the entire region. The nearby kingdom of Cambodia was weak, and accepted French control in exchange for defense against its neighbor, Siam (Thailand), as did Laos. Vietnam alone resisted French pressure for further concessions, eventually calling on China for aid.